Among the elderly, we often can find reduced abilities for complex decision making and slowing of performance.

2.2.7- Old age – Personal and social adjustments

The time at which old age begins is still ill defined. Sixty years is taken as the arbitrary dividing line.

Age divisions during old age:

- **The young -old (60-69 years)** This is a transition period marked by many adjustments such as retirement and declining strength, sharp reduction in expectation and behaviours.
- **Middle-aged old (70-79 years)** This period is characterized by increasing deaths of friends and spouse, reduced participation in home and community activities, increasing health problems, contracting social world.
- **Old (80-89 years)** In this period, assistance is needed in maintenance of social contacts, there may be many health problems and some may become institutionalized or may lead a very sheltered life.
- **Very old (90 years and above)** Health problems are more severe and serious with very limited activity in this period.



Challenging Areas That Require Adjustments during Old Age

There are several challenges in different areas of old age which require adjustments and intervention. For the purpose of better understanding it can be discussed at four levels- biological, psychological, sociological or psychological or behavioural.

Biological aging and its challenges– It includes changes in sensory- motor performance, muscle strength, brittleness of skeletal structure, visual acuity and decreased reaction time and balance. These are examples of biological aging which may influence attitude and behaviour.

Psychological aging and its adjustments – This consists of a general decline in the mental abilities that accompany old age.

Sociological aging and its challenges – It refers to changes in social roles- loss of spouse, vulnerability to disease, compulsory or voluntary retirement, loss of income and loss of status.

Psycho- social aging and its challenges – It refers to systematic changes in personality needs, expectations and behaviours as well as changes in roles and changes in relation to others.

Specific Psychological Problems Faced By Old People

a) Feeling of inadequacy.
b) Lack sense of belonging and acceptance.
c) Economic insecurity.
d) Changing social attitudes
e) Feeling of loneliness, uncertainty, restlessness.

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